

VEGANISM - LIVE DEBATE MASTER SHEET

FACT FIRST • SIMPLE LANGUAGE • SOURCE DIRECTLY UNDER EACH CLAIM



WHAT IS VEGANISM? A philosophy and way of living that seeks to exclude animal exploitation and cruelty as far as possible and practicable. It is bigger than a diet: it also concerns clothing, testing, entertainment and other uses of animals.

EXPLOITATION = using an animal as a resource or for someone else's benefit.

SOURCE: The Vegan Society - formal definition <https://www.vegansociety.com/go-vegan/definition-veganism>

1. NUTRITION / HEALTH

Adequacy: Appropriately planned vegetarian diets, including vegan diets, can be nutritionally adequate and appropriate for all stages of the life cycle.

SOURCE: Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics position (2016)
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2016.09.025>

Protein: Plant foods contain all essential amino acids. Meeting total protein and calorie needs matters more than combining proteins at every meal.

SOURCE: Mariotti & Gardner, *Nutrients* (2019)
<https://doi.org/10.3390/nu1112661>

RCT evidence: An 8-week randomized identical-twin trial found lower LDL cholesterol, body weight and fasting insulin in the vegan group.

SOURCE: Landry et al., *JAMA Network Open* (2023)
<https://doi.org/10.1001/jamanetworkopen.2023.44457>

2. B12 / COMMON NUTRIENTS

B12: Vegans need a reliable B12 source from fortified foods or supplements. Needing B12 supplementation does not make a diet invalid; it makes B12 a nutrient that must be supplied.

SOURCE: NIH Office of Dietary Supplements

<https://ods.od.nih.gov/factsheets/VitaminB12-HealthProfessional/>

Iron / calcium / omega-3: These nutrients exist in plant foods; adequacy depends on food choice, fortification and, when appropriate, supplements - just as nutrient adequacy matters in any diet.

SOURCE: Melina et al., *J Acad Nutr Diet* (2016)
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2016.09.025>

3. PLANTS / SENTIENCE

"Plants feel pain": Plants sense and react to their environment, but current evidence does not show that plants consciously experience pain. They do not have animal-like brains or nervous systems.

SOURCE: Taiz et al., *Trends in Plant Science* (2020)
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.tplants.2020.05.005>

Sentience is not intelligence: The ethical issue is whether a being can have subjective experiences such as pain or distress - not whether it can solve human-style problems.

SOURCE: Birch et al., *LSE sentience review* (2021)
<https://www.lse.ac.uk/business/consulting/assets/documents/invertebrate-sentience.pdf>

4. "ANIMALS EAT ANIMALS" / OMNIVORES

Animals eat animals: What wild animals do tells us what happens in nature; it does not tell humans what is morally justified when we can choose alternatives.

SOURCE: Logic: appeal-to-nature distinction
<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/moral-animal/>

"Humans are omnivores": Being able to eat animal foods does not prove that animal foods are nutritionally required. Ability is not necessity.

SOURCE: Academy of Nutrition and Dietetics (2016)
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jand.2016.09.025>

5. CROPS / CROP DEATHS

Crop deaths: Crop farming can harm animals. Veganism does not claim zero harm. The relevant question is which food system uses fewer resources and causes less avoidable animal use overall.

SOURCE: Poore & Nemecek, *Science* (2018)
<https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aag0216>

Feed conversion: Feeding human-edible crops to animals and then eating the animals loses food calories compared with direct human consumption.

SOURCE: Cassidy et al., *Environmental Research Letters* (2013)
<https://doi.org/10.1088/1748-9326/8/3/034015>

6. DEFORESTATION / SOY

Global soy use: About 77% of global soy is used for livestock feed; only a small share is eaten directly as soy foods.

SOURCE: Our World in Data synthesis of FCRN/USDA data
<https://ourworldindata.org/soy>

Deforestation: Pasture expansion for cattle has been a much larger direct driver of Brazilian Amazon forest loss than soy for human foods.

SOURCE: Tyukavina et al., *Science Advances* (2017)
<https://doi.org/10.1126/sciadv.1601047>

7. ENVIRONMENT / LAND

Land efficiency: Animal products use about 83% of global farmland while providing about 18% of calories and 37% of protein; a no-animal-product scenario cut modeled agricultural land use about 76%.

SOURCE: Poore & Nemecek, *Science* (2018)
<https://doi.org/10.1126/science.aag0216>

Real-world diets: Vegan diets were about 25% of high-meat diets for greenhouse-gas emissions and land use in a 55,504-person UK analysis.

SOURCE: Scarborough et al., *Nature Food* (2023)
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s43016-023-00795-w>

8. "HUMANE" / LOCAL / FREE-RANGE

Welfare vs rights: Better conditions can reduce some suffering, but "humane," "local" or "free-range" does not answer the separate question: was breeding, using or killing the animal necessary?

SOURCE: Ethical distinction; welfare evidence reviewed by EFSA
<https://www.efsa.europa.eu/en/topics/topic/animal-welfare>

Transport: Scientific welfare assessments identify heat stress, thirst, fatigue, pain, fear and distress as transport hazards for farmed animals.

SOURCE: EFSA Journal - animal transport opinions
<https://www.efsa.europa.eu/en/topics/topic/animal-welfare>

9. DAIRY / EGGS / SLAUGHTER

Dairy: Milk production requires reproduction. Dairy systems produce calves, separate many calves from dams, and cows eventually leave production and are commonly slaughtered.

SOURCE: Meagher et al., *Applied Animal Behaviour Science* (2019)
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.applanim.2018.11.011>

Eggs: Egg production is an animal-use system involving breeding and eventual culling/slaughter; welfare problems can include bone damage, injurious pecking and confinement depending on system.

SOURCE: Lay et al., *Poultry Science* (2011)
<https://doi.org/10.3382/ps.2010-00962>

10. FISH / AQUATIC ANIMALS

Fish pain: Reviews find evidence consistent with pain perception in fish, including nociception, learning and behavioral changes after harmful stimulation.

SOURCE: Sneddon et al., *Philosophical Transactions B* (2014)
<https://doi.org/10.1098/rstb.2013.0086>

Scale: Estimated numbers of farmed finfish killed for food are in the tens to hundreds of billions annually; wild-caught finfish estimates are far larger.

SOURCE: Mood et al., *Animal Welfare* (2024)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/38487450/>

11. CLIMATE / WATER / BIODIVERSITY

Climate: The IPCC finds diets high in plant protein and low in meat and dairy are associated with lower greenhouse-gas emissions, with land-sparing and nutrient-loss co-benefits.

SOURCE: IPCC AR6 WGIII, Chapter 12
<https://www.ipcc.ch/report/ar6/wg3/chapter/chapter-12/>

Water / pollution / biodiversity: Vegan diets were about 46% of high-meat diets for water use, 27% for eutrophication and 34% for biodiversity impact.

SOURCE: Scarborough et al., *Nature Food* (2023)
<https://doi.org/10.1038/s43016-023-00795-w>

12. COST / AFFORDABILITY

Food cost: In a U.S. randomized trial, a low-fat vegan diet reduced total food costs by about 16% compared with participants' baseline diets.

SOURCE: Kahleova et al., *JAMA Network Open* (2023)
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37669055/>

Simple reality: A vegan diet does not require specialty substitutes: beans, lentils, rice, oats, pasta, potatoes and seasonal/frozen produce can form the inexpensive base.

SOURCE: Study above + basic commodity foods
<https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/37669055/>

13. PUBLIC HEALTH

Antimicrobial resistance: Antimicrobial use in food animals can select for resistant organisms; reducing unnecessary antimicrobial use is a major One Health goal.

SOURCE: Tang et al., *Lancet Planetary Health* (2017)
[https://doi.org/10.1016/S2542-5196\(17\)30141-9](https://doi.org/10.1016/S2542-5196(17)30141-9)

Zoonotic disease: Many emerging infectious diseases are zoonotic. Land-use change, wildlife contact and livestock systems can influence spillover risk.

SOURCE: Jones et al., *Nature* (2008)
<https://doi.org/10.1038/nature06536>

14. ONE PERSON / PERSONAL CHOICE

"One person does not matter": Markets respond to combined demand. No single purchase has to cause one animal death for purchases collectively to influence production.

SOURCE: Consumer ethics / expected-demand argument
<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/vegetarianism/>

"Personal choice": A choice stops being only personal when it deliberately uses another sentient being. The disagreement is about whose interests count.

SOURCE: Ethical argument - not a scientific claim
<https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/moral-animal/>

15. FARMERS / TRANSITION

Farmers: A pro-vegan transition should include farmers, workers and rural communities. Moving away from animal agriculture does not mean abandoning farmers; it means changing what is produced and supporting the transition.

SOURCE: Practical examples: Transformation + Rowdy Girl Rancher Advocacy
<https://transformationproject.org/> | <https://rowdygirlsanctuary.org/>

Remember: Farmer-transition programs are practical examples, not peer-reviewed scientific evidence. Use them when someone asks, "What happens to farmers?"

SOURCE: Source type clearly labeled
<https://transformationproject.org/>

GO VEGAN - Facts. Evidence. Compassion.

Learn more, explore the evidence & get resources:

michaelsboost.com/govegan/